

The Theotokos Prayer Rule

Our venerable father Seraphim of Sarov gave his blessing to go around the holy groove/ditch (kanvaka) at the Diveyevo monastery while reading the prayer "Theotokos and Virgin, rejoice ..." 150 times. *Batushka [Seraphim] said: "Whoever walks this Kanavka with prayer, and reads one hundred and fifty prayers to the Mother of God, for such a person everything is here: Athos, and Jerusalem, and Kiev!"*

15 decades, consisting of:

"O Theotokos and Virgin, rejoice, Mary, full of grace, the Lord is with thee; blessed art thou among women, and blessed is the Fruit of thy womb, for thou hast borne the Savior of our souls." (10 times)

The Our Father (once)

The door of compassion open unto us, O blessed Theotokos, for, hoping in thee may we not perish; through thee may we be delivered from adversities, for thou art the salvation of the Christian race. (once)

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Additional prayers may be prayed after each decade. This rule was fulfilled by the Hieromartyr Seraphim (Zvezdinsky) and in doing so he prayed for the whole world while embracing the entire life of the Heavenly Queen.

The first decade: We remember the Nativity of the Blessed Virgin Mary. Here, we offer prayers for mothers, fathers, and children.

*“O Most Holy Lady Theotokos, save
and protect thy servants (names of
parents and relatives),*

and to the departed (names)

*grant rest with the saints in thine
eternal glory.”*

The second decade: We remember the Entry into the Temple of the Blessed Virgin Mary. Here we pray for those who have gone astray and fallen away from the Church.

“O, Most-Holy Lady Theotokos, save and protect and reunite (or join) to the Holy Orthodox Church thy lost and fallen away servants (names).”

The third decade: We remember the Annunciation of the Most Holy Theotokos. Here we pray for the soothing of sorrows and consolation of those who mourn.

“O, Most-Holy Lady Theotokos, soothe our sorrows and send consolation to thy servants (names)”

who are grieving or sick.”

The fourth decade: We remember the Meeting of the Most Holy Theotokos with Righteous Elizabeth. Here we pray for the reunion of those who have been estranged and those missing or separated from relatives or children.

“O, Most-Holy Lady Theotokos, unite Thy servants (names)

who have been separated.”

The fifth decade: We remember the Nativity of Christ and we pray for the rebirth of souls and for the new life that is in Christ.

“O, Most-Holy Lady Theotokos, grant me, who was baptized into Christ, to put on Christ.”

The sixth decade: We remember the Meeting of the Lord and the word prophesied by St. Symeon: “And a sword will pierce thy soul.” Here we pray that the Mother of God would meet our soul at the hour of death and that we would be worthy, with our last breath, to partake of the Holy Mysteries and that She would lead the soul through the terrible ordeals [toll-houses].

“O, Most-Holy Lady Theotokos, grant me with my last breath to partake of the Holy Mysteries of Christ and do thou thyself lead my soul through the terrible ordeals [of the toll-houses].”

The seventh decade: We remember the flight of the Mother of God with the Divine Infant to Egypt. Here we pray that the Heavenly Queen would help us to avoid temptations in this life and save us from misfortunes.

“O, Most-Holy Lady Theotokos, let me not be led into temptation in this life and deliver me from all misfortunes.”

The eighth decade: We remember how the twelve-year-old Jesus was seemingly lost during a trip to Jerusalem and how the Mother of God grieved over this. Here we pray, asking the Mother of God for the constant praying of the Jesus Prayer.

“O, Most-Holy Lady Theotokos, Most-Pure Virgin Mary, grant me to pray unceasingly the Jesus Prayer.”

The ninth decade: We remember the miracle in Cana of Galilee when the Lord turned water into wine according to the word of the Mother of God: “They have no wine.” Here we ask the Mother of God for help in our undertakings and for deliverance from need.

“O, Most-Holy Lady Theotokos, help me in every enterprise and deliver me from all needs and sorrows.”

The tenth decade: We remember how the Mother of God stood at the Cross of the Lord and sorrow, like a sword, pierced Her soul. Here we pray to the Most-Pure One for the strengthening of our spiritual fortitude and for the driving away of despondency.

“O, Most-Holy Lady Theotokos, Blessed Virgin Mary, strengthen my spiritual fortitude and drive despondency far from me.”

The eleventh decade: We remember the Resurrection of Christ and prayerfully ask the Mother of God to resurrect our soul and give new vigor to our spiritual contest [podvig].

“O, Most-Holy Lady Theotokos, resurrect my soul and grant me constant readiness for spiritual contest [podvig].”

The twelfth decade: We remember the Ascension of Christ, at which the Mother of God was present. Here we pray and ask the Heavenly Queen to raise the soul above earthly and vain amusements and direct it towards striving for heavenly things.

“O, Most-Holy Lady Theotokos, deliver me from vain thoughts and grant me a mind and a heart that strives for the salvation of the soul.”

The thirteenth decade: We remember the upper chamber at Zion and the descent of the Holy Spirit on the apostles and the Mother of God while praying:
“Create a pure heart in me, O God, and renew a right spirit within me. Cast me not away from Thy presence, and take not Thy Holy Spirit from me.”

“O, Most-Holy Lady Theotokos, send down into my heart and strengthen within it the grace of the Holy Spirit.”

The Fourteenth decade: We remember the Dormition of the Most Holy Theotokos and ask for a peaceful and serene death.

“O, Most-Holy Lady Theotokos, grant me a peaceful and serene ending to my life.”

The fifteenth decade: We remember the glory of the Mother of God with which She is crowned by the Lord after She was taken from earth to Heaven, and we pray the Heavenly Queen not to forsake the faithful who are on earth, but to protect them from all evil, covering them with Her Most-Honorable Omophor [Protection].

“O, Most-Holy Lady Theotokos, save me from all evil and cover me with Thy Most-Honorable Omophor [Protection].”

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